

My Trucks Are Sitting Idle — How Do I Keep Them Booked?

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A moving truck that doesn't move is costing you money. Not vaguely — precisely.

If your truck can realistically complete 6 jobs per week at \$700 average, and it's doing 3, you're leaving \$2,100 on the table every week. Every week. That's \$8,400 per month. From a truck you already own, insured, and maintained.

Before you buy another truck, hire another crew, or change your pricing — fix the idle problem first.

Why Moving Trucks Sit Idle

There are only three real reasons a moving truck isn't booked:

Not enough inbound demand. Your marketing isn't generating enough inquiries to fill your schedule. This is the most common cause and the most fixable.

Demand exists but you're not capturing it. Potential customers are searching, calling competitors, or bouncing from your website because you don't answer fast enough, your reviews aren't strong enough, or your booking process has friction.

Wrong service mix. If most of your trucks are set up for large full-day moves and your market has strong demand for smaller 2-hour apartment moves, you have a structural mismatch.

The Utilization Metric You Should Track

Utilization rate = Booked hours ÷ Available hours per week

A truck running 8-hour days, 5 days per week has 40 available hours. If it's generating 24 hours of booked moves per week, your utilization is 60%.

Industry benchmark for healthy operations: 70 to 85%.

Below 60%: You have a marketing problem.

60 to 70%: You have a conversion problem (demand exists but you're not capturing it).

Above 85%: You're approaching capacity — start thinking about when to add a truck.

Calculate your utilization now. If you don't know the number, you can't fix it.

Strategy 1: Speed-to-Lead

In the moving industry, the first company to respond to an inquiry wins a disproportionate share of bookings. Research consistently shows that responding within 5 minutes of an inquiry generates 3 to 4x more conversions than responding within 30 minutes.

Most moving companies don't respond within 5 minutes. The operator who answers immediately — or has a booking system that confirms immediately — wins jobs that everyone else loses.

Practical implementation:

- Set up call forwarding so inquiries reach you immediately
- Add an online booking option to your website — customers who can book without calling will often book at midnight when you're asleep

- Use an automated text response for missed calls: "Thanks for calling [Company]. We're with a customer — I'll call you back in X minutes." This holds the lead.

Strategy 2: Fill Off-Peak Gaps With Off-Peak Pricing

Moving demand is not evenly distributed across the week or month. Weekends and end-of-month dates are heavily booked. Tuesday mornings in the middle of the month are usually open.

Instead of having a flat rate, offer midweek and mid-month discounts of 10 to 20%. Customers with flexibility will take them. Your truck goes from idle on Tuesday to booked — at a slight discount but far better than zero.

This is yield management — the same principle airlines and hotels use. Apply it to your schedule and your utilization climbs significantly.

Strategy 3: Build a Last-Minute Booking Channel

Many moves are booked 1 to 3 days in advance. Customers whose original mover fell through, customers who just decided to move, customers who couldn't find anyone else available.

If you have open slots in the next 48 hours, that information needs to be findable. Options:

- A "last-minute availability" section on your website updated weekly
- A Google Post saying "Available this week — call for same-day or next-day moves"
- A dedicated page targeting "same-day movers [city]" — this search term has high intent and low competition in most markets

Last-minute jobs often command a premium. Customers who need immediate help are less price-sensitive. Your idle truck becomes your highest-margin job of the week.

Strategy 4: Add a Recurring Commercial Relationship

One corporate relocation client or office moving relationship can add 4 to 10 moves per month with zero ongoing marketing cost. Corporate clients move employees consistently — once you're on their approved vendor list, moves come in without you finding them.

Call 5 local HR departments or office managers this week. Introduce your company. Ask if they have a moving vendor. If not, offer to do their next move at a reduced rate to get on the list.

Commercial clients don't generate Google reviews, but they generate predictable, recurring revenue — which is exactly what an idle truck needs.

Strategy 5: Add a Demand Channel That Has No Off Days

Word-of-mouth and organic search generate jobs when they feel like it. They're not channels you control. When you have idle trucks, you need a channel you can turn on.

This is the role pay-per-move fills. A partner who brings you customers — and who only gets paid when a job completes — has every incentive to keep your trucks full. Their revenue goes to zero when your trucks sit idle. That alignment is valuable.

The Consequence Question

Before moving on from this, sit with this for a moment.

If you have 2 trucks and each is running at 60% utilization when 80% is achievable — what does that gap actually cost you annually?

- $2 \text{ trucks} \times 40 \text{ available hours/week} \times 20\% \text{ idle gap} = 16 \text{ wasted hours/week}$
- At \$175/hour average billing rate: \$2,800/week
- Annual: **\$145,600 in revenue that could exist but doesn't**

That's not a small number. And it's generated by trucks you already own, crews you already manage, and a market that already has demand. The only missing piece is getting those customers to choose you.

Want to close that utilization gap? Book a free strategy call and we'll show you what's available in your market.